Why did Nikita Khrushchev want to send nuclear missiles to Cuba? This seems such a basic question, yet historians still argue about the answer. Generally, they do not display the same interest in why Eisenhower deployed Thor missiles in Britain or why he and Kennedy deployed Jupiter missiles in Italy and Turkey. There are certainly similarities that make for interesting comparisons (discussed later). Yet the idea that Khrushchev's decision is the starting point, and that the crisis arose from Soviet action and US reaction, reflects an unconscious (or not so unconscious) bias.

Philip Nash's 1994 book, *The Other Missiles of October,* remains the essential reference point in understanding Western missile deployments.[46] The author traces the complex, and for Washington, frustrating dynamics of the NATO alliance. At one point an exasperated Eisenhower grumbled that 'it would have been better to have dumped them in the ocean instead of trying to dump them on our allies'.[47] Nash also illustrates the strategic logic of forward-basing IRBMs using the equation: IRBM + NATO = ICBM. While this equation might also characterise Soviet action (M/IRBM + Cuba = ICBM), Khrushchev's agenda reflected various other concerns.

In his memoirs. Khrushchev offers the following explanation for the decision:

> The main thing was that the installation of our missiles in Cuba would, I thought, restrain the United States from precipitous military action against Castro's government. In addition to protecting Cuba, our missiles would have equalized what the West likes to call "the balance of power". The Americans had surrounded our country with military bases and threatened us with nuclear weapons, and now they would learn just what it feels like to have enemy missiles pointing at you; we'd be doing nothing more than giving them a little of their own medicine.[48]

Less prosaically, he is supposed to have asked his Defence Minister, Marshal Rodion Malinovsky, 'What about putting one of our hedgehogs down the American's trousers?'[49]